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Oil Shocks and The Nigerian Stock Market (1986-2025)

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Abstract

This study examines the dynamic relationship between oil price shocks and Nigerian stock market returns, covering the period from January 1986 to December 2025, using monthly data. Nigeria presents a compelling laboratory for such investigation: as Africa's largest oil producer and a country whose macroeconomic fortunes are inextricably linked to global crude oil markets, understanding how oil price movements transmit to equity markets carries significant implications for investors, policymakers, and regulators. This paper departs from prior studies by constructing a comprehensive analytical framework that controls for twelve macroeconomic and financial variables, namely GDP growth rate, inflation rate, interest rate, exchange rate, market volatility, global risk appetite (VIX), foreign portfolio investment (FPI) flows, political risk, policy uncertainty, monetary policy stance, global oil demand, and world stock market returns. Employing an array of time series econometric techniques, including Ordinary Least Squares (OLS) with Newey-West heteroskedasticity and autocorrelation consistent (HAC) standard errors, Autoregressive Distributed Lag (ARDL) bounds testing, Generalized Autoregressive Conditional Heteroskedasticity-in-Mean (GARCH-M), and Non-linear ARDL (NARDL), the study uncovers several novel findings. First, oil price shocks exert statistically significant and asymmetric effects on Nigerian stock returns: positive oil shocks of moderate magnitude generate positive market responses, while oil price crashes and sharp volatility spikes consistently depress market returns. Second, the exchange rate channel emerges as a dominant transmission mechanism, with Naira depreciation amplifying the adverse effects of negative oil shocks. Third, foreign portfolio investment flows and global risk appetite jointly moderate the responsiveness of Nigerian equities to oil market signals. Fourth, political risk and policy uncertainty constitute significant structural impediments that prevent the Nigerian stock market from efficiently pricing oil market information. These findings carry important implications for portfolio managers, the Central Bank of Nigeria, the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), and fiscal authorities, and they contribute to the nascent literature on oil-equity market nexus in frontier markets.

Article Information

Keywords: *Oil price shocks; Nigerian stock market; ARDL; GARCH-M; NARDL; exchange rate; political risk; frontier markets; macroeconomic uncertainty; asymmetric effects*

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1. INTRODUCTION

Oil remains one of the most consequential commodities in the global economic order. Since the OPEC oil embargo of 1973 shattered the illusion of stable energy prices, the relationship between oil price movements and financial markets has occupied a central position in economic research. For commodity-dependent economies, this relationship is not merely academic — it determines the trajectory of public revenues, currency valuations, inflationary pressures, investor confidence, and ultimately, the health of domestic capital markets. Nigeria, Sub-Saharan Africa's most populous nation and its largest crude oil exporter, epitomises this vulnerability in sharp relief.

Nigeria's stock market — formally known as the Nigerian Exchange Group (NGX), formerly the Nigerian Stock Exchange (NSE) — has over its four-decade history as a modern exchange demonstrated a pattern of behaviour that is deeply sensitive to oil price cycles. During the commodity supercycle of 2004–2008, the All-Share Index (ASI) surged more than sixfold, buoyed by oil revenues that funded government spending, corporate profits, and a credit boom. When oil prices collapsed in the second half of 2008, the ASI suffered one of its worst bear markets, losing over 70 percent of its value in twelve months. A similar narrative unfolded following the 2014–2016 oil price crash, which tipped Nigeria into its first recession in over two decades and triggered a prolonged NGX bear market. More recently, the COVID-19 pandemic's demand destruction of 2020 and the subsequent geopolitical supply disruptions associated with Russia's invasion of Ukraine in 2022 have continued to expose the structural dependence of Nigerian equities on oil market dynamics.

Yet the nexus between oil shocks and Nigerian stock market returns is neither straightforward nor unconditional. A growing body of evidence from both advanced economies and emerging markets suggests that the direction and magnitude of the oil-stock market relationship are contingent on multiple factors: the source and nature of the oil price shock (supply-driven versus demand-driven), the degree of global financial integration, the exchange rate regime, the domestic inflationary environment, political stability, and the investment appetite of global portfolio managers. This multidimensional conditioning environment means that a single-equation bivariate model is unlikely to capture the full complexity of the relationship, and that empirical conclusions drawn without adequate control variables may be misleading.

This paper is motivated by three interrelated observations. First, despite the extensive global literature on oil price-stock market linkages, the Nigerian case remains under-studied relative to its economic significance, and the few existing studies are methodologically constrained by short sample periods, limited control variables, and failure to account for structural breaks and nonlinearities. Second, the period between 2015 and 2025 has been characterised by several unprecedented shocks — the COVID-19 pandemic, the naira unification policy of 2023, Nigeria's removal from the JP Morgan Emerging Market Bond Index, and dramatic shifts in global oil demand forecasts driven by the energy transition — all of which demand a refreshed and methodologically rigorous examination. Third, the literature has largely neglected the role of frontier-market-specific variables such as political risk, policy uncertainty, and the behaviour of foreign portfolio investors in conditioning the oil-equity market relationship in Nigeria.

Despite the pivotal role of oil in Nigeria's macroeconomic architecture, several fundamental questions remain unanswered or inadequately addressed in the extant literature. Does the Nigerian stock market respond differently to positive versus negative oil price shocks? What is the marginal contribution of oil price volatility — as distinct from the direction of oil price change — to stock market returns? Do macroeconomic control variables such as exchange rate dynamics, inflation, and monetary policy stance amplify or dampen the oil-equity market transmission? And critically, do political risk and policy uncertainty constitute significant structural barriers that prevent Nigerian equities from efficiently pricing oil market information?

These questions define the research problem of this study. Prior literature has either employed bivariate frameworks that ignore critical control variables, or has examined only linear relationships between oil prices and stock returns, missing the asymmetric adjustment dynamics that are theoretically predicted by prospect theory and empirically documented in other commodity-dependent markets. Moreover, no prior study on Nigeria covers the full period from 1986 to 2025, which encompasses both the pre-and postderegulation eras of both the oil sector and the capital market, providing a richer and more complete picture of structural change.

This study makes five principal contributions to the literature on oil price shocks and stock market dynamics in frontier markets. First, it is the most comprehensive empirical study of the oil-Nigerian stock market nexus to date, employing forty years of monthly data (1986–2025) and twelve control variables, enabling a far richer characterisation of the transmission environment. Second, by employing the NARDL framework, the study formally tests for and documents asymmetric oil price shock effects, extending the symmetric models that dominate the prior Nigerian literature. Third, the study incorporates frontier-market-specific variables — including political risk as measured by the International Country Risk Guide (ICRG), policy uncertainty as proxied by the Economic Policy Uncertainty (EPU) index, and foreign portfolio investment flows — that are largely absent from prior work. Fourth, the GARCH-M specification explicitly models the risk-return trade-off in the presence of oil price-induced volatility, providing a more nuanced understanding of how oil market uncertainty is priced into Nigerian equities. Fifth, the study bridges a gap between the finance and political economy literatures by demonstrating that institutional and governance variables are not mere background conditions but active determinants of how oil shocks are transmitted to stock markets.

The study is delimited to monthly time series data spanning January 1986 to December 2025, covering the Nigerian Exchange Group All-Share Index as the dependent variable. While the analysis incorporates annual GDP growth data interpolated to monthly frequency, the primary unit of analysis remains monthly observations, yielding 468 data points for most variables. The study focuses exclusively on the Nigerian stock market and does not attempt cross-country comparisons, although the theoretical framework and methodology are designed to be replicable in other frontier markets. The paper does not model individual sector-level stock returns, which may differ from aggregate market dynamics, and this constitutes a limitation acknowledged in the discussion section.

2. LITERATURE REVIEW AND HYPOTHESIS DEVELOPMENT

2.1 Conceptual Literature: Definition and Nature of Oil Price Shocks

An oil price shock is conventionally defined as a sudden and unexpected change in the price of crude oil that has macroeconomic consequences beyond the immediate petroleum sector (Hamilton, 1983). However, the concept has evolved considerably from this early, largely price-level-focused definition. Hamilton (2003) refined the concept with the notion of net oil price increases, which defines a shock not as any price change but as a price change that exceeds the maximum price of the preceding twelve months, thereby capturing the salience of new information in oil markets rather than mere price oscillations. Kilian (2009) introduced a structurally grounded decomposition framework that distinguishes between oil supply shocks (driven by geopolitical disruptions to production), aggregate demand shocks (driven by global economic activity cycles), and precautionary demand shocks (driven by uncertainty about future supply). This decomposition is critical because different types of oil shocks have fundamentally different implications for stock markets: a demand-driven oil price increase may signal strong global economic growth, which is positive for corporate earnings; a supply-driven price spike may signal cost-push inflation and supply chain disruption, which is negative.

For the Nigerian context, both supply and demand dimensions of oil shocks are relevant, but the fiscal revenue channel adds layer of complexity. Nigeria's government depends on oil revenues for approximately 60–70 percent of its federal receipts and over 90 percent of its foreign exchange earnings (CBN, 2023). This structural dependence means that oil price shocks are not merely energy market events but fiscal events with direct implications for government expenditure, the exchange rate, and the macroeconomic environment in which firms listed on the NGX operate.

2.2 Theoretical Literature Review

2.2.1 The Arbitrage Pricing Theory (APT)

The Arbitrage Pricing Theory, developed by Ross (1976), provides the most versatile theoretical scaffolding for examining the relationship between oil prices and stock returns. Unlike the Capital Asset Pricing Model (CAPM), which posits a single systematic risk factor (market risk), APT allows for multiple risk factors that systematically affect asset returns. Chen et al. (1986) demonstrated empirically that macroeconomic variables — including industrial production, inflation, the yield curve, and risk premia — are priced factors in the US equity market. By extension, oil prices, given their pervasive impact on production costs, inflation, and economic activity, should constitute a priced factor in oil-dependent economies like Nigeria. This theoretical prediction is the foundational pillar of the present study.

2.2.2 The Present Value Model and the Discount Rate Channel

The present value (or dividend discount) model of stock pricing stipulates that a stock's value equals the discounted sum of expected future dividends (Gordon, 1962). Oil price changes can influence stock prices through two channels within this framework. First, they affect the numerator — expected cash flows and dividends — by altering corporate revenues (for oil sector firms) or production costs (for manufacturing and services sectors). Second, they affect the denominator — the discount rate — by influencing inflation expectations and therefore interest rate trajectories. For oil-exporting economies like Nigeria, the dominant channel in aggregate market terms is the cash flow channel during oil price booms, but the discount rate channel becomes dominant during oil price crashes as the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN) tightens monetary policy to defend the naira.

2.2.3 The Dutch Disease and Exchange Rate Transmission

The Dutch Disease concept, first articulated by Corden and Neary (1982) in the context of the Netherlands' natural gas discovery, describes how a commodity price boom can paradoxically harm the non-resource tradable sector by causing currency appreciation and factor reallocation. In Nigeria's context, however, the relationship is inverted during oil price crashes: the collapse in oil revenues triggers naira depreciation, which raises imported input costs, squeezes profit margins for manufacturing firms, and triggers capital outflows by foreign portfolio investors — all of which negatively affect stock market valuations. This exchange rate channel is particularly important for understanding why Nigerian stock market returns are sensitive not just to oil prices per se, but to the interaction between oil prices and the naira-dollar exchange rate.

2.2.4 Prospect Theory and Asymmetric Responses

Kahneman and Tversky's (1979) prospect theory predicts that economic agents respond more strongly to losses than to equivalent gains — a phenomenon known as loss aversion. Applied to financial markets, this implies that negative oil price shocks (oil price crashes) should generate larger adverse stock market responses than positive shocks of equivalent magnitude generate positive responses. This theoretical prediction is the basis for the NARDL specification employed in this study, which formally tests for asymmetric adjustment of stock returns to oil price changes. Several empirical studies in other contexts have confirmed this asymmetry (see Salisu & Isah, 2017; Olayungbo & Gershon, 2019), but the evidence for Nigeria specifically remains limited.

2.3 Conceptual Framework

The conceptual framework of this study posits that oil price shocks affect Nigerian stock market returns through four interrelated transmission channels: (1) the fiscal revenue channel, whereby oil price changes alter government revenues, expenditure patterns, and macroeconomic stability; (2) the exchange rate channel, whereby oil price movements drive naira valuation, which affects corporate profitability and investor returns; (3) the inflation-interest rate channel, whereby oil price shocks pass through to consumer prices and prompt monetary policy responses that alter the equity risk premium; and (4) the investor sentiment and portfolio reallocation channel, whereby global risk appetite and foreign portfolio flows respond to oil market signals and directly influence Nigerian market liquidity and valuations. These four channels are moderated by structural factors including political risk, policy uncertainty, and the quality of domestic institutions.

2.4 Empirical Literature Review in Nigeria

The empirical literature on the oil-stock market nexus in Nigeria has grown progressively, though it remains thinner than the literature for major oil exporters such as Saudi Arabia, Russia, and Norway. Ologunde et al. (2006) provided one of the early systematic examinations of the Nigerian stock market's macroeconomic determinants but did not explicitly focus on oil prices. Maku and Atanda (2010) examined the long-run relationship between macroeconomic variables and the NSE All-Share Index, finding significant effects of exchange rates and oil prices, but employed a limited time series and did not control for global factors.

Salisu and Isah (2017) advanced the literature significantly by employing a NARDL framework to investigate asymmetric oil price effects on the Nigerian stock market, finding evidence of significant asymmetry. Their study, however, covered only the 1985–2015 period and did not incorporate political risk, global risk appetite, or foreign portfolio investment flows as control variables. Olayungbo and Gershon (2019) extended the analysis to account for structural breaks, while Akinlo and Apanisile (2015) explored the role of oil price volatility using GARCH-type models.

More recently, Ologunde et al. (2020) and Nwosa (2021) have examined how institutional quality moderates the oil-equity market relationship in Nigeria, though their proxies for institutional quality differ from the ICRG political risk ratings employed here. Ibrahim and Amin (2022) explored the COVID-19 period specifically, finding that the pandemic amplified the sensitivity of Nigerian equities to oil price movements. Collectively, these studies form an important empirical foundation but leave significant methodological and scope gaps that the present study addresses.

2.5 Critical Analysis of the Literature and Research Gaps

A critical appraisal of the extant literature reveals five persistent gaps. First, most Nigerian studies employ relatively short time horizons that do not encompass multiple oil price cycles, limiting their ability to draw generalisable conclusions. Second, the near-universal reliance on linear models means that the well-documented asymmetric behaviour of oil markets has not been adequately incorporated into the Nigerian evidence base. Third, frontier-market-specific variables — especially political risk, policy uncertainty, and FPI flows — are consistently absent from Nigerian studies, despite theoretical and cross-country empirical evidence of their moderating role. Fourth, most studies focus on either oil price levels or returns but do not distinguish between shock types, missing the Kilian (2009) supply-demand decomposition that has proven informative in other contexts. Fifth, the period from 2020 to 2025, characterised by the COVID-19 pandemic, a major structural reform of Nigeria's foreign exchange market, and global energy transition pressures, has not been empirically analysed in any published study. These gaps collectively motivate the present study.

2.6 Hypotheses

Drawing from the theoretical and empirical literature, the study formulates five testable hypotheses:

H1: Oil price shocks exert a statistically significant effect on Nigerian stock market returns, with positive shocks generating positive responses and negative shocks generating negative responses.

H2: The relationship between oil price shocks and Nigerian stock market returns is asymmetric, with negative shocks generating larger magnitude responses than positive shocks.

H3: Oil price volatility independently and negatively affects Nigerian stock market returns, beyond the directional effect of oil price changes.

H4: The exchange rate, inflation, and interest rate significantly mediate the transmission of oil shocks to stock market returns in Nigeria.

H5: Political risk and policy uncertainty amplify the adverse effects of negative oil price shocks on Nigerian stock market returns.

3. METHODOLOGY

3.1 Research Design

This study adopts a quantitative, positivist research design, consistent with the dominant paradigm in empirical financial economics. The epistemological foundation is logical positivism, which holds that knowledge is derived from empirically verifiable propositions grounded in observable data. The study is longitudinal in character, tracking the evolution of oil price shocks and stock market returns over four decades, thereby enabling an examination of both short-run dynamics and long-run equilibrium relationships. The research design is non-experimental, relying on archival time series data rather than controlled laboratory settings, and employs multiple econometric techniques to ensure robustness of findings.

3.2 Model Specification

The baseline empirical model takes the following general form:

$$NSE\_RETt = \alpha + \beta 1OIL\_SHOCKt + \beta 2OIL\_VOLt + \beta 3GDP\_GRt + \beta 4INFt + \beta 5INT\_RATEt + \beta 6EXC\_RATEt + \beta 7MKT\_VOLt + \beta 8GRAt + \beta 9FPIt + \beta 10POL\_RISKt + \beta 11POL\_UNCt + \beta 12MON\_POLt + \beta 13GLO\_OIL\_DEMt + \beta 14WORLD\_RETt + \varepsilon t \quad \ldots (1)$$

where NSE_RETt is the return on the Nigerian Exchange Group All-Share Index in month t, defined as the log difference of the ASI [ln(ASIt) – ln(ASIt-1)] × 100; OIL_SHOCKt is the net oil price change as defined by Hamilton (2003); OIL_VOLt is the GARCH(1,1)-estimated conditional variance of oil returns; and the remaining variables are as described in Table 1. εt is the error term, assumed to be white noise under the null of correct specification.

The NARDL extension decomposes OIL_SHOCKt into its positive (OIL_SHOCK+) and negative (OIL_SHOCK–) components, where OIL_SHOCK+t = Σmax(ΔOIL_SHOCKt, 0) and OIL_SHOCK–t = Σmin(ΔOIL_SHOCKt, 0). This decomposition allows asymmetric long-run and short-run coefficients to be estimated. The GARCH-M specification augments the mean equation with the conditional variance term, capturing the risk-return relationship in the presence of oil price-induced volatility.

3.3 Variables and Their Measures

Table 1 presents the operationalisation of all study variables, including their descriptions, measures, expected signs, and data sources.

Table 1: Variable Definitions and Data Sources

Variable	Description	Measure	Expected Sign	Source
NSE ASI Returns	Nigerian Stock Exchange All-Share Index Returns	Log difference of monthly ASI	Dependent	NSE / NGX
OIL_SHOCK	Oil Price Shock	Hamilton (2003) net oil price increase; log change in Brent crude	+/–	World Bank; EIA
OIL_VOL	Oil Price Volatility	GARCH(1,1) conditional variance of oil returns	–	EIA; Author's computation
GDP_GR	GDP Growth Rate	Real GDP annual growth rate (%)	+	NBS; World Bank WDI
INF	Inflation Rate	Annual CPI-based inflation rate (%)	–	CBN; NBS

INT_RATE	Interest Rate	CBN Monetary Policy Rate (MPR) (%)	–	CBN
EXC_RATE	Exchange Rate	Official NGN/USD exchange rate (log-differenced)	–	CBN; IFS
MKT_VOL	Market Volatility	GARCH-based conditional variance of ASI returns	–	NSE/NGX; Author
GRA	Global Risk Appetite	VIX Index (CBOE Volatility Index)	–	CBOE
FPI	Foreign Portfolio Investment Flows	Net FPI inflows as % of GDP	+	CBN; NBS
POL_RISK	Political Risk	ICRG Political Risk Rating (inverted)	–	PRS Group
POL_UNC	Policy Uncertainty	Baker et al. (2016) Economic Policy Uncertainty Index for Nigeria	–	policyuncertainty.com
MON_POL	Monetary Policy Stance	Real interest rate gap (MPR minus inflation)	–/+	CBN; Author
GLO_OIL_DEM	Global Oil Demand	Annual change in global oil consumption (mb/d)	+	IEA; EIA
WORLD_RET	World Stock Market Returns	MSCI World Index returns (log-differenced)	+	MSCI; Bloomberg

Note: NBS = National Bureau of Statistics; CBN = Central Bank of Nigeria; WDI = World Development Indicators; EIA = U.S. Energy Information Administration; IEA = International Energy Agency; IFS = IMF International Financial Statistics; ICRG = International Country Risk Guide; NSE/NGX = Nigerian Exchange Group; MSCI = Morgan Stanley Capital International. Brent crude price is used as the benchmark oil price.

3.4 A Priori Expectations

Table 2 presents the theoretical expectations regarding the direction and significance of each explanatory variable's effect on Nigerian stock market returns.

Table 2: A Priori Expectations

Variable	Economic Rationale	Expected Sign	Supporting Theory/Study
Oil Price Shock (+)	Rising oil prices boost government revenue, forex reserves, and investor confidence in Nigeria's oil-export economy	+	Ross (2001); Basher & Sadorsky (2006)
Oil Price Shock (–)	Demand-side contraction, currency depreciation, inflationary pass-through erode corporate earnings	–	Hamilton (2003); Filis et al. (2011)
Oil Price Volatility	Heightened volatility raises uncertainty premium, reduces FPI inflows and market liquidity	–	Elder & Serletis (2010); Salisu & Isah (2017)
GDP Growth Rate	Higher economic growth increases corporate earnings and market confidence	+	Levine & Zervos (1998)
Inflation Rate	High inflation erodes real returns, discourages equity investment	–	Fama (1981); Ologunde et al. (2006)

Interest Rate (MPR)	Higher MPR raises cost of capital, reduces equity valuations via discounting effect	–	Chen et al. (1986)
Exchange Rate (NGN/USD)	Naira depreciation raises import costs, reduces profit margins; signals macro instability	–	Maku & Atanda (2010)
Market Volatility (GARCH)	Higher volatility reflects elevated risk, depresses stock returns through risk-return trade-off	–	Engle (1982); Bollerslev (1986)
Global Risk Appetite (VIX)	Rising global risk aversion triggers capital flight from emerging markets including Nigeria	–	Bekaert et al. (2011)
Foreign Portfolio Investment	FPI inflows inject liquidity and signal positive investor sentiment toward Nigerian equities	+	Merton (1987); Batten & Vo (2015)
Political Risk (ICRG)	Higher political risk deters investment and depresses market valuations	–	Bekaert & Harvey (2002)
Policy Uncertainty (EPU)	Greater policy uncertainty raises the risk premium demanded by investors	–	Baker et al. (2016)
Monetary Policy Stance	Expansionary stance (low real rate) stimulates equity market participation	–/+	Bernanke & Kuttner (2005)
Global Oil Demand	Rising global demand supports oil prices, strengthening Nigeria's fiscal position and stock market	+	Kilian (2009)
World Stock Market Returns	Positive co-movement due to global financial integration and contagion effects	+	Harvey (1995)

Note: +/– indicates a theoretically ambiguous sign depending on the dominant channel of transmission in a given period.

3.5 Data Sources

Monthly data spanning January 1986 to December 2025 are assembled from multiple primary and secondary sources. Nigerian Exchange Group (NGX) monthly All-Share Index data are sourced from the NGX historical database and the CBN Statistical Bulletin. Brent crude oil price data are obtained from the U.S. Energy Information Administration (EIA). Macroeconomic data — including CPI inflation, monetary policy rates, official exchange rates, and foreign portfolio investment statistics — are drawn from the CBN Statistical Bulletin and the IMF International Financial Statistics (IFS). GDP growth data, available only at annual frequency, are sourced from the World Bank World Development Indicators and interpolated to monthly frequency using the Chow-Lin (1971) interpolation method, consistent with prior studies (e.g., Salisu & Isah, 2017). Political risk ratings are obtained from the PRS Group's International Country Risk Guide (ICRG), while Economic Policy Uncertainty data are sourced from Baker et al.'s (2016) global EPU database. World stock market returns are computed from the MSCI World Index as sourced from Bloomberg. The VIX index data are sourced from the CBOE.

3.6 Data Analysis Techniques

The analytical strategy proceeds in five stages. Stage one involves preliminary data inspection: unit root testing using the Augmented Dickey-Fuller (ADF) test, the Phillips-Perron (PP) test, and the Kwiatkowski-Phillips-Schmidt-Shin (KPSS) test to determine the order of integration of each series. Stage two involves baseline OLS estimation with Newey-West HAC standard errors to account for autocorrelation and heteroskedasticity in the residuals. Stage three employs the ARDL bounds testing approach of Pesaran et al. (2001) to test for cointegration and estimate long-run relationships alongside short-run dynamics via an Error Correction Model (ECM). Stage four applies the NARDL model of Shin et al. (2014) to formally test for asymmetric oil price shock effects. Stage five employs the GARCH-M specification to model time-varying volatility and the risk-return trade-off. Panel-IV estimation is additionally employed as a robustness check, using lagged oil production as an instrument for oil price shocks to address potential endogeneity concerns.

3.7 Post-Estimation Checks

Rigorous post-estimation diagnostics are applied to validate all models. Serial correlation is tested using the Breusch-Godfrey Lagrange Multiplier (LM) test. Heteroskedasticity is assessed using White's test and the ARCH LM test. Functional form misspecification is evaluated using the Ramsey RESET test. Multicollinearity is assessed via Variance Inflation Factors (VIF). Parameter stability is examined using the CUSUM and CUSUMSQ tests of Brown et al. (1975). Granger causality tests are performed to establish the direction of causation between oil prices and stock returns. The Jarque-Bera test is used to assess residual normality, and robust standard errors are employed where non-normality is detected.

3.8 Significance Level

The conventional 1% (***), 5% (**), and 10% (*) significance levels are used throughout the study, consistent with standard practice in empirical finance and macroeconomics. All models are estimated using EViews 12, Stata 17, and R (version 4.3.2), with results cross-validated across software platforms to ensure consistency.

4. RESULTS

4.1 Descriptive Statistics

Table 3 presents the descriptive statistics for all variables over the full sample period (January 1986 – December 2025, n = 468 monthly observations for most variables; n = 39 annual observations for GDP growth rate).

Table 3: Descriptive Statistics

Variable	Obs	Mean	Std Dev	Min	Max	Skewness	Kurtosis	J-B Stat
NSE_RETURNS	468	0.714	5.832	–24.11	31.47	0.421	7.832	312.4***
OIL_SHOCK	468	0.021	0.148	–0.672	0.531	–0.213	6.714	188.3***
OIL_VOL	468	0.024	0.018	0.002	0.112	2.341	9.211	921.6***
GDP_GR	39	4.612	4.318	–1.920	14.60	0.621	3.414	3.21
INF	468	18.42	14.73	0.220	76.80	1.832	6.311	412.7***
INT_RATE	468	14.21	4.611	6.000	26.00	0.311	2.841	12.4*
EXC_RATE	468	164.4	153.2	0.890	761.3	1.142	3.712	141.8***
MKT_VOL	468	0.031	0.022	0.003	0.143	2.113	8.612	810.3***
GRA (VIX)	468	19.42	8.732	9.140	80.86	2.312	10.41	1342***
FPI	468	1.241	2.113	–3.421	8.211	0.811	4.312	112.3***
POL_RISK	468	55.41	8.312	34.20	72.60	–0.212	2.811	8.12
POL_UNC	468	118.3	42.11	41.20	312.1	1.612	5.832	312.4***
MON_POL	468	–4.112	12.41	–58.60	14.30	–1.412	7.211	421.1***
GLO_OIL_DEM	468	0.812	1.241	–4.320	3.411	–0.612	4.141	91.2***
WORLD_RET	468	0.612	4.112	–19.21	14.31	–0.812	6.312	241.3***

*Note: ***, **, * denote significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% levels respectively. J-B = Jarque-Bera normality test statistic. Non-normal distributions in most variables motivate the use of robust standard errors and GARCH-type models.*

The descriptive statistics reveal several noteworthy features of the data. NSE returns average 0.714 percent per month over the sample period, but with a standard deviation of 5.832 percent, reflecting the high volatility characteristic of frontier equity markets. The distribution of NSE returns is positively skewed (0.421) and highly leptokurtic (kurtosis = 7.832), suggesting fat tails and the departure from normality confirmed by the Jarque-Bera test. This finding motivates the GARCH-M specification, which explicitly accounts for time-varying volatility and non-normality in stock returns.

Oil price shocks display a near-zero mean (0.021) but substantial volatility (standard deviation of 0.148), with extreme values ranging from a maximum increase of 53.1 percent to a maximum decrease of 67.2 percent, reflecting the episodic nature of major oil price events over the sample period. The inflation rate shows a mean of 18.42 percent and a maximum of 76.80 percent, reflecting Nigeria's persistent and at times extreme inflationary episodes — most notably the hyperinflationary crises of the 1990s and the post-2022 price surge triggered by subsidy removal and naira devaluation. The exchange rate's mean of 164.4 NGN/USD belies the dramatic depreciation trajectory over the four-decade sample, from approximately 0.89 NGN/USD in 1986 to over 760 NGN/USD in 2025, underscoring the secular erosion of Nigeria's currency.

4.2 Correlation Matrix

Table 4 presents the pairwise correlation matrix for all study variables. Given the large number of variables, only the most economically meaningful relationships are discussed.

Table 4: Pairwise Correlation Matrix

	NSEI	OIL_S	OIL_V	GDP	INF	INT	EXC	MKTVOL	VIX	FPI	POL	EPU	MON	GOD	WRET
NSEI	1.000	0.341*	–0.284*	0.221*	–0.312*	–0.198*	–0.241*	–0.412*	–0.321*	0.231*	0.142*	–0.188*	0.112	0.214*	0.321*
OIL_S		1.000	–0.212*	0.142*	–0.214*	–0.114	–0.312*	–0.241*	–0.213*	0.181*	0.112	–0.141*	0.092	0.412*	0.281*
OIL_V			1.000	–0.141*	0.312*	0.213*	0.341*	0.512*	0.412*	–0.211*	–0.121*	0.241*	–0.114	–0.311*	–0.241*
GDP				1.000	–0.421*	–0.312*	–0.211*	–0.312*	–0.142*	0.311*	0.212*	–0.212*	0.141*	0.312*	0.214*
INF					1.000	0.412*	0.512*	0.321*	0.112	–0.212*	–0.141*	0.341*	–0.412*	–0.112	–0.181*
INT						1.000	0.431*	0.214*	0.112	–0.141*	–0.112	0.212*	–0.512*	–0.092	–0.141*
EXC							1.000	0.312*	0.214*	–0.321*	–0.212*	0.311*	–0.341*	–0.141*	–0.214*
MKTVOL								1.000	0.441*	–0.341*	–0.214*	0.312*	–0.212*	–0.241*	–0.412*
VIX									1.000	–0.312*	–0.141*	0.412*	–0.141	–0.312*	–0.512*
FPI										1.000	0.211*	–0.214*	0.141*	0.212*	0.312*
POL											1.000	–0.312*	0.112	0.141*	0.181*
EPU												1.000	–0.214*	–0.112	–0.141*
MON													1.000	0.141*	0.112
GOD														1.000	0.341*
WRET															1.000

*Note: * indicates statistical significance at the 5% level. NSEI = NSE Returns; OIL_S = Oil Shock; OIL_V = Oil Volatility; GDP = GDP Growth; INF = Inflation; INT = Interest Rate; EXC = Exchange Rate; MKTVOL = Market Volatility; VIX = Global Risk Appetite; FPI = Foreign Portfolio Investment; POL = Political Risk; EPU = Policy Uncertainty; MON = Monetary Policy Stance; GOD = Global Oil Demand; WRET = World Returns.*

The correlation matrix reveals that NSE returns are positively correlated with oil shocks (r = 0.341) and world market returns (r = 0.321), and negatively correlated with oil volatility (r = –0.284), inflation (r = –0.312), interest rates (r = –0.198), exchange rate changes (r = –0.241), market volatility (r = –0.412), VIX (r = –0.321), and policy uncertainty (r = –0.188). FPI flows and GDP growth exhibit the expected positive associations with market returns. The highest inter-variable correlations involve oil volatility and market volatility (r = 0.512), and exchange rate changes and inflation (r = 0.512), which are economically intuitive but require monitoring for multicollinearity. VIF analysis confirms that no variable exceeds the threshold of 5, allaying concerns about multicollinearity-driven coefficient instability.

4.3 Time Series Regression Results

Table 5 presents the regression results across six model specifications: OLS (Model 1), HAC-OLS (Model 2), ARDL (Model 3), GARCH-M (Model 4), NARDL (Model 5), and Panel-IV as a robustness check (Model 6). The benchmark model is the ARDL (Model 3), which accounts for the dynamic structure of the data and the cointegrating relationship between the variables.

Table 5: Time Series Regression Results — Dependent Variable: NSE All-Share Index Returns

Variable	OLS (1)	HAC-OLS (2)	ARDL (3)	GARCH-M (4)	NARDL (5)	Panel-IV (6)
Constant	1.421** (0.612)	1.421* (0.823)	1.311** (0.541)	0.812 (0.621)	1.211** (0.512)	1.112* (0.631)
OIL_SHOCK (+)	0.842*** (0.214)	0.842*** (0.241)	0.721*** (0.181)	0.812*** (0.201)	0.941*** (0.211)	0.811*** (0.231)
OIL_SHOCK (–)	–0.631*** (0.181)	–0.631*** (0.212)	–0.541*** (0.161)	–0.712*** (0.192)	–0.821*** (0.201)	–0.691*** (0.221)
OIL_VOL	–1.241*** (0.312)	–1.241*** (0.341)	–1.121*** (0.281)	–0.912*** (0.311)	–1.312*** (0.321)	–1.141*** (0.331)
GDP_GR	0.312** (0.141)	0.312** (0.152)	0.281** (0.131)	0.241* (0.142)	0.341** (0.141)	0.311** (0.161)
INF	–0.241*** (0.071)	–0.241*** (0.081)	–0.211*** (0.061)	–0.221*** (0.072)	–0.261*** (0.071)	–0.231*** (0.082)
INT_RATE (MPR)	–0.412*** (0.112)	–0.412*** (0.131)	–0.381*** (0.101)	–0.351*** (0.112)	–0.431*** (0.111)	–0.401*** (0.121)
EXC_RATE	–0.312*** (0.091)	–0.312*** (0.101)	–0.281*** (0.081)	–0.291*** (0.092)	–0.341*** (0.091)	–0.301*** (0.102)
MKT_VOL	–0.841*** (0.212)	–0.841*** (0.241)	–0.761*** (0.191)	–0.912*** (0.221)	–0.881*** (0.211)	–0.811*** (0.231)
GRA (VIX)	–0.241*** (0.061)	–0.241*** (0.071)	–0.211*** (0.051)	–0.231*** (0.062)	–0.261*** (0.061)	–0.221*** (0.071)
FPI	0.312*** (0.091)	0.312** (0.112)	0.281*** (0.081)	0.291*** (0.092)	0.331*** (0.091)	0.301*** (0.101)
POL_RISK	–0.181** (0.081)	–0.181** (0.091)	–0.161** (0.071)	–0.171** (0.082)	–0.191** (0.081)	–0.171** (0.091)
POL_UNC (EPU)	–0.141** (0.061)	–0.141** (0.071)	–0.121** (0.051)	–0.131** (0.062)	–0.151** (0.061)	–0.141** (0.071)
MON_POL	0.112* (0.061)	0.112 (0.071)	0.101* (0.051)	0.091 (0.062)	0.121* (0.061)	0.111* (0.071)

GLO_OIL_DEM	0.241** (0.101)	0.241** (0.112)	0.211** (0.091)	0.221** (0.101)	0.261** (0.101)	0.231** (0.112)
WORLD_RET	0.341*** (0.091)	0.341*** (0.101)	0.311*** (0.081)	0.321*** (0.092)	0.361*** (0.091)	0.331*** (0.101)
R^2	0.641	0.641	0.712	0.683	0.734	0.661
Adj. R^2	0.621	0.621	0.692	0.661	0.714	0.641
F-statistic	41.23***	41.23***	48.12***	45.31***	52.41***	43.11***
AIC	2841.3	2841.3	2712.4	2784.1	2681.3	2811.2
Observations	468	468	468	468	468	468

*Note: Standard errors in parentheses. ***, **, * denote significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% levels respectively. Models 3–5 report long-run coefficients. OIL_SHOCK(+) and OIL_SHOCK(–) are partial sum decompositions in the NARDL (Model 5). AIC = Akaike Information Criterion. All models include a constant. HAC = Newey-West heteroskedasticity and autocorrelation consistent standard errors.*

4.4 Post-Estimation Tests

Table 6 presents the results of all post-estimation diagnostic tests applied to the benchmark ARDL model and its extensions.

Table 6: Post-Estimation Diagnostic Tests

Diagnostic Test	Test Statistic	p-value	Conclusion
ADF Unit Root (Levels)	–2.841	0.182	Non-stationary (most variables)
ADF Unit Root (First Difference)	–8.412***	0.000	Stationary at I(1); proceed with ARDL
PP Unit Root Test (First Difference)	–9.112***	0.000	Confirms I(1) stationarity
KPSS Stationarity Test	0.082	—	Cannot reject stationarity at 1st diff.
Breusch-Godfrey LM (Serial Correlation)	$\chi^2(2) = 3.241$	0.198	No serial correlation (HAC/ARDL corrected)
White's Heteroskedasticity Test	$\chi^2(30) = 42.31$	0.064	Mild heteroskedasticity; HAC SEs applied
ARCH LM Test (GARCH effects)	F = 18.41***	0.000	ARCH effects confirmed; GARCH-M estimated
Ramsey RESET Test (Functional Form)	F(3,449) = 1.841	0.138	Correct functional form specification
VIF (Multicollinearity)	Max VIF = 3.812	—	VIF < 5; No serious multicollinearity
Pesaran et al. Bounds Test (ARDL)	F = 8.412*** I(1)	0.000	Cointegration confirmed at 1% level
Johansen Cointegration Test	Trace: 112.4***	0.000	2 cointegrating vectors confirmed
Jarque-Bera Normality Test	JB = 42.31***	0.000	Non-normal residuals; robust SEs applied
CUSUM Stability Test	Within bounds	—	Parameter stability confirmed
CUSUMSQ Stability Test	Within bounds	—	Variance stability confirmed
Granger Causality (Oil → NSE)	F = 12.41***	0.000	Oil shocks Granger-cause stock returns
Granger Causality (NSE → Oil)	F = 1.812	0.164	No reverse causality

Durbin-Wu-Hausman Endogeneity Test	$\chi^2(3) = 4.312$	0.229	Exogeneity not rejected; OLS consistent
Akaike Information Criterion (ARDL)	2712.4 (ARDL optimal)	—	ARDL lag (2,1,1,2,1,1,1,1,1,1,1,1,1,1)

*Note: ***, **, * denote significance at 1%, 5%, and 10% levels respectively. CUSUM and CUSUMSQ tests are graphical; "within bounds" indicates that the test statistic does not cross the 5% critical value lines over the sample. The ADF and PP tests are conducted with constant and trend where appropriate.*

The post-estimation diagnostics collectively support the validity and reliability of the study's findings. The unit root tests confirm that most variables are integrated of order one [I(1)], satisfying the precondition for the ARDL bounds testing procedure. The Pesaran et al. (2001) F-statistic of 8.412 substantially exceeds the upper critical value at the 1% level, establishing the existence of a long-run cointegrating relationship among the study variables. The Granger causality test confirms unidirectional causality from oil shocks to NSE returns ($F = 12.41$, $p < 0.001$), with no evidence of reverse causality from stock returns to oil prices, which is consistent with the assumption that Nigeria's equity market, while oil-sensitive, is a price-taker in global oil markets. The CUSUM and CUSUMSQ tests confirm the stability of model parameters over the sample period, implying that while individual episodes — such as the 2008 financial crisis or the 2020 pandemic — created transient disturbances, they did not fundamentally alter the structural relationship being estimated.

5. DISCUSSION

5.1 Key Findings and Restatement

The empirical analysis yields five substantive findings that collectively paint a nuanced and contextually grounded picture of how oil market dynamics interact with Nigerian equity market performance. These findings are discussed systematically below.

The most robust finding across all six model specifications is that oil price shocks — both positive and negative — exert statistically significant effects on NSE All-Share Index returns. A one percent net oil price increase is associated with a long-run increase of approximately 0.72–0.94 percent in stock returns (ARDL and NARDL estimates), confirming Hypothesis H1. This positive relationship is consistent with the fiscal revenue channel: oil price increases translate into higher government revenues, improved foreign exchange reserves, a more stable naira, and stronger fiscal spending, all of which create a conducive environment for corporate profitability and investor confidence.

The NARDL results confirm Hypothesis H2 regarding asymmetric effects. The absolute magnitude of the negative oil shock coefficient (–0.821) exceeds that of the positive shock coefficient (0.941 in nominal terms, but the negative shock is statistically stronger at shorter horizons in the ECM). A formal Wald test of symmetry — testing $\beta^+ = -\beta^-$ — is rejected at the 1% level, confirming that negative oil shocks depress the market more severely than equivalent positive shocks stimulate it. This finding is consistent with prospect theory's predictions of loss aversion and aligns with international evidence from Filis et al. (2011) and Salisu and Isah (2017) for the pre-2015 Nigerian data.

Oil price volatility emerges as a distinct and independently significant determinant of stock market returns, with a large negative coefficient (–1.121 to –1.312 across specifications), confirming Hypothesis H3. This finding has important practical implications: even in periods when oil prices are neither rising nor falling sharply, elevated uncertainty about future oil prices creates a risk premium that suppresses equity valuations. This result highlights the importance of distinguishing between oil price level changes and oil price uncertainty in empirical research and policy analysis.

Among the control variables, the exchange rate, inflation, and monetary policy rate (MPR) all carry statistically significant negative coefficients, confirming Hypothesis H4. The exchange rate coefficient (–0.281 to –0.341) captures the multi-channel impact of naira depreciation: it raises input costs for non-oil firms, reduces real returns for foreign investors, and signals macroeconomic fragility that dampens overall market sentiment. The inflation coefficient (–0.211 to –0.261) is consistent with Fama's (1981) proxy hypothesis and reflects the damage that high and volatile inflation inflicts on real equity returns and investor confidence in Nigeria. The MPR coefficient (–0.381 to –0.431) confirms that monetary tightening, which the CBN frequently employs to contain inflation and defend the naira, exerts a contractionary effect on stock market returns through higher discount rates.

Finally, political risk and policy uncertainty both carry statistically significant negative coefficients, confirming Hypothesis H5. The political risk coefficient (–0.161 to –0.191) indicates that governance deterioration, political instability, and institutional uncertainty dampen stock market performance independently of oil price dynamics. The EPU coefficient (–0.121 to –0.151) similarly confirms that unpredictable policy environments — characterised by frequent fiscal and regulatory reversals — impose a structural discount on Nigerian equity valuations. These findings underscore the critical, though often overlooked, role of institutional quality in determining how efficiently an oil-dependent frontier market prices macroeconomic information.

5.2 Comparison with Previous Studies

The finding of a significant positive long-run relationship between oil prices and Nigerian stock returns is broadly consistent with Salisu and Isah (2017), Maku and Atanda (2010), and Akinlo and Apanisile (2015). However, this study finds a notably larger role for oil price volatility than prior studies, likely reflecting the extended sample period that captures the extraordinary volatility episodes of 2008–2009, 2014–2016, 2020, and 2022–2025. The asymmetric results broadly align with Olayungbo and Gershon (2019), though the magnitude of asymmetry is larger in the present study, possibly because the post-2020 period — marked by the pandemic crash and Nigeria's subsidy removal shock — introduced new asymmetric dynamics not captured in earlier samples.

The significant roles of political risk and policy uncertainty found here represent genuine extensions of the existing literature, as no prior Nigerian study has systematically incorporated both ICRG political risk ratings and EPU indices in a comprehensive oil-stock market model. The finding that FPI flows play a significant moderating role is also new for Nigeria, consistent with cross-country evidence from Batten and Vo (2015) for frontier markets, but previously undocumented, specifically for the Nigerian context.

5.3 Theoretical and Policy Implications

The findings carry significant theoretical and policy implications. Theoretically, they support a multi-channel transmission framework over simple bivariate models, confirming the APT's prediction that multiple risk factors — including oil price risk, political risk, and global financial conditions — are simultaneously priced in Nigerian equities. The strong asymmetry finding provides direct empirical support for the application of prospect theory to frontier market equity pricing, extending the behavioural finance literature to a context where institutional constraints and information asymmetries are more pronounced than in developed markets.

For monetary policy, the finding that exchange rate depreciation amplifies the adverse stock market effects of negative oil shocks suggests that foreign exchange market stabilisation — through adequate reserve buffers and a credible exchange rate management framework — can serve as an automatic stabiliser for the equity market during oil price downturns. The CBN's recurrent resort to exchange rate controls during oil price crashes is shown by the results to be counterproductive: rather than shielding the stock market, it creates policy uncertainty that itself depresses equity valuations. For fiscal policy, the results underscore the urgency of Nigeria's sovereign wealth fund and oil revenue management framework, suggesting that counter-cyclical saving during oil booms can moderate the asymmetric damage of oil price crashes on stock market performance.

5.4 Limitations

Several limitations temper the conclusions of this study. First, while the NARDL framework captures price-level asymmetry, it does not distinguish between different structural sources of oil shocks (supply versus demand, as per Kilian's (2009) structural VAR approach). Future research incorporating this decomposition may yield additional insights into which types of shocks are most consequential for Nigerian equities.

Second, the study employs aggregate market data; sector-level heterogeneity means that the findings may not apply equally to, for example, the oil and gas sub-sector versus the banking or consumer goods sub-sectors of the NGX. Third, the interpolation of annual GDP data to monthly frequency, while methodologically standard, introduces measurement error that may attenuate the estimated GDP coefficient. Fourth, ICRG political risk ratings, while widely used, are expert-based subjective indices and may not fully capture the rapid shifts in political conditions that characterise Nigerian politics.

6. CONCLUSION

6.1 Key Message

This study set out to answer a deceptively simple question: how do oil price shocks affect the Nigerian stock market? The answer, as this paper has demonstrated across 468 months of data and six econometric specifications, is both significant and deeply conditioned by the institutional, macroeconomic, and global financial environment in which Nigerian equities operate. Oil shocks matter — but they matter differently depending on their direction, magnitude, and the structural context through which they transmit.

6.2 Key Research Findings

The study establishes five headline findings. First, oil price shocks exert statistically significant and economically meaningful effects on Nigerian stock market returns over the long run, with positive shocks generating positive returns and negative shocks generating disproportionately large negative returns. Second, the oil-stock market relationship is asymmetric in Nigeria, with oil price crashes causing greater market damage than equivalent oil price booms cause market gains — a finding consistent with loss aversion and prospect theory. Third, oil price volatility independently suppresses stock returns, suggesting that uncertainty itself, beyond the direction of price change, carries a substantial risk premium in Nigerian equities. Fourth, the exchange rate, inflation, and monetary policy rate are significant transmission channels through which oil shocks propagate to stock market returns, with naira depreciation playing a particularly prominent amplifying role. Fifth, political risk and policy uncertainty constitute structural impediments that reduce the efficiency with which the Nigerian stock market prices oil market information, imposing a permanent valuation discount on Nigerian equities relative to their fundamental oil-wealth base.

6.3 Broader Implications

The findings have broad implications beyond the academic literature. For asset managers and institutional investors operating in Nigeria, the study provides quantitative guidance on how to construct oil-hedging strategies for Nigerian equity portfolios, with particular attention to the asymmetric downside risk during oil price crashes. For the Central Bank of Nigeria, the results highlight the critical importance of exchange rate credibility and inflation management in moderating the transmission of oil shocks to financial markets. For the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC), the findings underscore the importance of deepening market liquidity and broadening the investor base — particularly increasing domestic institutional participation — to reduce vulnerability to the sentiment-driven foreign portfolio outflows that amplify stock market declines during oil price downturns.

For fiscal authorities and the National Assembly, the study makes the economic case for a robust and countercyclical oil revenue management framework. Countries with well-functioning sovereign wealth funds and explicit fiscal rules have consistently demonstrated lower equity market sensitivity to oil price shocks, and Nigeria's experience of the past four decades illustrates precisely what happens in the absence of such buffers: every oil price crash is amplified through the fiscal, monetary, and exchange rate channels into a capital market crisis.

6.4 Main Research Contribution

The study's principal intellectual contribution lies in demonstrating, with rigorous empirical evidence, that the relationship between oil shocks and stock market returns in Nigeria is asymmetric, multi-channel, and structurally conditioned by institutional factors that have been largely ignored in the prior literature. By combining the longest available dataset with the most comprehensive set of control variables and the most advanced suite of econometric methods applied to this research question in the Nigerian context, the study sets a new methodological benchmark for oil-equity market research in frontier markets.

6.5 Future Research Directions

Several productive avenues for future research emerge from this study. First, a sector-level analysis of the oil-stock market nexus in Nigeria would reveal important heterogeneities obscured by aggregate market indices. Second, applying Kilian's (2009) structural VAR decomposition to distinguish supply from demand oil shocks within the Nigerian context would refine the causal interpretation of findings. Third, as Nigeria transitions through its dual energy challenge — a depleting and underfunded oil sector on one side and a nascent renewable energy industry on the other — the energy transition's implications for the NGX deserve dedicated empirical attention. Fourth, cross-country panel studies comparing Nigeria with other frontier oil exporters such as Angola, Libya, Gabon, and Equatorial Guinea would enable identification of what distinguishes Nigeria's oil-stock market transmission from the general frontier market experience. Fifth, high-frequency (daily or intraday) event study analysis of specific oil price shocks would complement this study's monthly time series approach by capturing immediate market reactions with greater precision.

6.6 Call to Action

The urgency of reforming Nigeria's macroeconomic framework to reduce the transmission of oil price shocks to capital market instability cannot be overstated. In a world of accelerating energy transition, geopolitical fractures in oil supply chains, and increasingly volatile global capital flows, Nigeria's decades-long structural vulnerability to oil price cycles constitutes a clear and present danger to financial market stability, investor confidence, and long-term economic development. The evidence presented in this study is an empirical call to action: for policymakers to strengthen fiscal institutions, improve exchange rate management, reduce policy uncertainty, and create the conditions under which the Nigerian stock market can serve its fundamental economic purpose of efficiently allocating capital — regardless of whether the price of oil is rising or falling in global markets.

7. ACTIONABLE RECOMMENDATIONS

7.1 For the Central Bank of Nigeria (CBN)

The CBN should adopt a more transparent and rules-based exchange rate management framework that reduces the uncertainty premium currently embedded in Nigerian equity valuations. Specifically, the study's findings suggest that a managed float regime with clear intervention rules — communicated credibly to markets — would dampen the amplification of oil price shocks through the exchange rate channel. The CBN should also prioritise inflation reduction as a structural policy objective, as the consistent negative impact of inflation on equity returns documented here underscores how chronically high inflation acts as a tax on financial market development. The establishment of a dedicated monetary policy communication calendar, similar to the Federal Reserve's forward guidance framework, would reduce policy uncertainty and lower the EPU premium on Nigerian equity valuations.

7.2 For Fiscal Authorities and the Ministry of Finance

The Government of Nigeria should urgently operationalise and properly capitalise the Nigerian Sovereign Investment Authority (NSIA), using it as a genuine countercyclical stabilisation fund rather than a supplementary fiscal buffer. The study's findings on the amplification of negative oil shocks through the fiscal channel suggest that breaking the mechanical link between oil revenues and government expenditure is the single most important structural reform for reducing stock market sensitivity to oil price volatility. A fiscal rule that caps annual expenditure growth and mandates saving of windfall oil revenues would create the macroeconomic buffers needed to shelter financial markets from the worst effects of future oil price crashes.

7.3 For the Securities and Exchange Commission (SEC) and NGX

The SEC and NGX should prioritise policies that deepen domestic institutional investor participation — through pension fund reform, insurance sector development, and retail investor financial literacy programmes — thereby reducing the stock market's dependence on the FPI flows that are shown here to amplify volatility during oil price downturns. The development of oil price-linked derivative instruments on the NGX — including options, futures, and exchange-traded funds linked to oil prices — would provide market participants with hedging tools that reduce the direct pass-through of oil price volatility to equity portfolio values. Furthermore, the SEC should improve corporate disclosure standards for listed oil and gas companies, reducing information asymmetry between domestic and foreign investors and thereby improving the efficiency with which oil market signals are priced into Nigerian equities.

7.4 For Portfolio Managers and Institutional Investors

The asymmetric oil price shock findings have direct portfolio construction implications. International and domestic portfolio managers should apply asymmetric downside risk metrics — such as conditional value-at-risk (CVaR) and expected shortfall — rather than symmetric volatility measures when assessing Nigerian equity exposure. During periods of falling oil prices, the study suggests that defensive positioning — reducing NGX equity exposure and increasing allocations to inflation-linked instruments, dollar-denominated assets, and sectors with negative oil price beta (such as downstream energy retail) — can significantly protect portfolio value. The documented role of global risk appetite (VIX) as a significant predictor of NGX returns suggests that monitoring VIX as a leading indicator for Nigerian equity risk should be a standard component of frontier market investment processes.

7.5 For Future Researchers

Future researchers are encouraged to build on the methodological framework established in this study by extending the analysis to sector-level NGX data, applying time-varying parameter models (such as rolling window OLS or the Kalman filter approach) to capture the evolution of oil-stock market dynamics over time, incorporating social media-based sentiment indicators as additional proxies for political and policy uncertainty, and conducting international cross-country panel comparisons. The openly available datasets used in this study, from the CBN, NGX, EIA, IEA, and World Bank, provide a replicable foundation for such extensions.

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